

Translation Studies

10. The teaching of translation

Krisztina Károly, Spring, 2006

Sources: Klaudy, 2003



Main questions:

- Can translation and interpretation be taught?
- What is it exactly that can/cannot be taught?
- How can the results of translation studies be applied in organising translation courses and making the teaching of translation more efficient?



The relationship between the study and the teaching of translation:

- translation studies grew out of the needs of teaching translation and training translators
- James Holmes (1972, creator of the term “TS”) identifies 3 branches within the field:
 - (1) theoretical
 - (2) descriptive
 - (3) **applied TS: translator training**, translation aids, translation policy, and translation criticism



Main sources of knowledge applied in the teaching of translation:

■ General conclusions:

- translation theory
- research

■ Specific solutions:

- translators' intuitive work, experience (no rules, generalizations!)



What can be of use in teaching?

James Holmes's (1972) classification:

Theoretical TS

- general → *cannot be applied in teaching*
- partial (special or concrete) → *CAN be applied in teaching!*
 - medium-restricted TS (man/machine translates)
 - area-restricted TS (languages involved)
 - text-type restricted TS (text type being translated)
- etc.

Descriptive TS

- product-,
- process-,
- function-oriented TS.



The role of contrastive linguistics in the teaching of translation:

- CL → comparison of specific language pairs and text types (in primary communication, NOT secondary = translation)
- Klaudy (2003):
 - TS looks at translation in a complex manner (Lic + extra-Lic factors influencing the process of translation)
 - Contrastive Lics and contrastive text Lics can be helpful only in the analysis of the Lic factors of translation, but in this they have a crucial function.



The translational "behaviour" of languages and transfer operations:

- Klaudy (1999): depending on the similarities and differences between Ls → a certain type of "translational behaviour" (cf. "friendly" and "unfriendly" L pairs);
e.g., English: friendly with German, less with French, not with Hungarian
- depending on the L pair and the directions of translation, the typological features of particular Ls determine the difficulties of translation
- the behaviour of L pairs towards each other determine some of the transfer operations as well → important in teaching



The transfer competence of translators

Consists of five elements:

- (1) linguistic competence,
- (2) subject-related competence,
- (3) inter-cultural competence,
- (4) transfer competence
- (5) communicative competence



“competence”:

- a particular type of knowledge (language proficiency, subject knowledge, knowledge about culture)
- skills (transfer skills, communication skills)



Transfer competence

- part of the translator's professional competence,
- can develop strategies to overcome problems resulting from the differences between the two languages
- can "freely move" between the two Ls: possesses general translation strategies + particular language-pair-specific strategies! (≠merely a mono- or bilingual speaker)



Modelling the process of translation

A **translator**, a professional bilingual person, differs from a speaker of language “A” or language “B” in that he/she knows and consciously or instinctively operates two rule-systems:

- (1) He/she knows the rules according to which signs of language “A” are used by speakers of language “A” to refer to reality (“A” system of rules);
- (2) He/she knows the rules according to which signs of language “B” are used by speakers of language “B” to refer to reality (“B” system of rules).



Modelling the process of translation, cont.

Process: the translator,

- with the help of the language "A" rule system, decodes the language "A" text and reaches reality (denotative model) or a semantic deep structure (one subtype of the transformational model);
- re-encodes this reality with the help of the language "B" system of rules to ultimately reach the language "B" text.

Path: **language "A" → reality → language "B"**



The characteristics of the "C" system of rules:

How come that Hungarian texts translated from a FL differ (linguistically) from original Hungarian texts? → 2 explanations:

- (1) The translator goes down to the deep structure from the language "A" surface, but then takes the wrong path towards the language "B" surface; or
- (2) The translator does not go down to the deep structure from the language "A" surface, but directly switches to the language "B" surface. In other words, he/she creates for him-/herself an intuitive translational rule system, a so-called "C" system of rules, and, consciously or unconsciously, applies this system during his/her work.



How can this "C" system of rules be characterised?

It is

- (1) **abstract** – while the rules of systems "A" and "B" relate L signs to reality, rules in the system "C" relate L signs to L signs;
- (2) **subjective** – while the rules of systems "A" and "B" are acquired within an institutional framework by speakers of language "A" and "B", rules in the system "C" are created intuitively by translators on the basis of their own experience;
- (3) **incidental** – the "C" system of rules may be distorted if the translator has received inadequate training in one of his/her Ls, or if he/she has received good training in both Ls but for some reason cannot relate them appropriately.



The dilemma of translator training

How should translator training deal with this "C" system of rules? → it must reckon with the existence of the "C" system of rules.

Two alternatives:

- (1) It can try to **eliminate** the "C" system of rules, and discourage translators from believing in a direct relationship between Ls "A" and "B" → translators should not bother with Lic form, but should try and grasp content (sense, meaning)
- (2) It can try to **improve and refine** the "C" system of rules, accepting the assumption that some form of relationship does exist, but in a considerably more complicated form than the one intuitively created by the translators → language "A" effects should be avoided by proposing a more sensitive and complicated system of relations (!)



The benefits of linguistic awareness-raising

- **for teachers of translation:** in designing translation courses, selecting texts to be translated, evaluating translations, and justifying teachers' and readers' corrections
- **for translator trainees:** without Lics only very low-level generalisations can be made from the translators' experience (e.g., "this does not sound nice in Hungarian", "we say this differently in Hungarian", "this doesn't sound OK", or "maybe you should phrase it differently") → the teacher should explain his/her corrections by highlighting the differences between the two L systems and their typical usages (= frame of reference in the decisions of future translators)
- **for practicing translators:** as a result of being aware of the regularities of Ls, the translator can multiply his/her own transfer experience + contributes to increasing the prestige of the profession (professional explanations of decisions)

